The 5th

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by Modus_0perand1

Summary

MAYDAY

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WE ARE UNDER ATTACK BY NEA FORCES

MAYDAY

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There was a sudden whistling in the air as the 5th NEA division began their defection from Great Leader. They had dug trenches beforehand, but it would seem that now, the NEA proper had wisened up to that fact, as the 5th sent out frantic radio broadcasts to rebel forces, asking for reinforcements. "Alert, alert, alert! Loyal forces of The Front, asking for help. We of the 5th NEA have defected, alert, alert, alert. We will soon be under attack by enemy forces."

The shells began to drop, exploding and sending up great plumes of dirt and bits of rock, smoke soon filling the air. The 5th's own artillery began sending back return fire, thundering as they did. It was deafening, but this is why the NEA had earplugs. A member of the infantry tapped the side of his head - he wasn't bleeding from the ears yet. That was lucky.

"Move, move, move!" Yelled the commissar of unit 2, as artillery fell all around them - they were under sudden infantry attack by the… Oh hell, that was the 7th, or so the radio from command said. Fellow troops dashed back and forth in the trenches, machine guns and rifle-fire chattering and snapping across the battlefield. They could see the battle flags of the 7th cresting the hills, and in tandem with those flags, were mechs, shit, those were mechs! Flying flags of the 6th, that was bad. As radios crackled out throughout the firing line, reporting the incoming enemy leg units, lead poured from the beastly machines into the 5th's troops, working through infantry like it was cutting grass.

However, as the mechs began to move forwards, landmines jumped up from under their metal-shodden feet, each exploding in glorious eruptions of flame, shrapnel, and high explosive. Mechs were thrown to the ground, soldiers around them simply reduced to pieces. That was less glorious, but to the 5th, it was practically like having She-Ra herself on their side.

The leg units of the 5th were encountering their own problems fighting in a forested area, as infantry from the 7th began to overwhelm them so much that they took to less shooting, instead

stomping and kicking, even firing on friendly armor and leg units so as to dislodge clambering tick-like anti-tank troops. They were drenched in red, pilots using cranial jack reflexes sparingly - "HOLD ON." Came the scream from the commanding officer, as his mech, a hulking Monarch, fired a cannon that seemed like it was ripped from a cruiser, sounding out across the landscape, ripping through trees, and leaving a massive crater in the ground.

He slammed his control sticks forwards, putting his full reflexes into swiveling the turret of the Monarch around to aim for the now-visible command vehicle of the infantry. It was towering, like a great radio tower on treads. He was almost in awe of it, before pressing a series of buttons and pulling switches to load another shell into the cannon. It fell in with a loud 'CLUNK', before the 'beep' from the console gave him the go-ahead to fire. He closed his eyes for a second, then held down on the triggers. The recoil shoved back the ill-prepared mech slightly, feet digging into the ground as the shell traveled forwards, meeting its destination of the command vehicle. Then the MG, the usual for any NEA mech, a solid 12.7mm, began to shudder and clack out its message in spent brass. The command vehicle seemed to stand still for a second, before violently shattering outwards with a mighty bang which shook even those in the mechs.

"Cut the head off the snake, and the snake will die." He whispered to himself, trying to calm down as the pain in his head intensified. He gritted his teeth and walked his mech backward, quickly ordering other surrounding units to follow him and pull back.

>command report: Leg units pulling back .
>recovering radio reports . . . .
>low friendly casualties(estimated casualties: 10 - 15)
>calculating . . . .
>high enemy casualties(estimated: 300 - 450)

The words popped up on the command readout, and Zhuka slammed her fist down, gripping the glove she held in it, growling. “Fuck. Fuck, fuck, fuck. Shit.” She sarcastically smiled. “At least we made them hurt for it.” She swallowed, then picked up the radio microphone and spoke into it. “General Busov! Are you men holding?”

Busov’s low voice sounded back to her at a quick, but calm, clip. “We are holding well, Ma’am - Field Marshal. Enemy leg units have not penetrated our lines, although we have suffered roughly 25% casualties.”

“Dammit. Sending you medical personnel - hold on, Busov.” She inputted the order into the terminal she stood in front of, before looking at the command reading again, typing out the command prompts needed.

>recovering reports . . . .
>”general busov”
>recovering units under command . . . .
>infantry: 1st, 4th, 5th, 3rd
>calculating . . . .
>medium friendly casualty rate(2 - 30, acceptable rate)

“You’re doing a bit better than you’re letting on, Busov. Keep at it. Medical personnel should be coming to you in under three minutes.” She chuckled, appreciating Busov’s underestimation. Made him put more work into tactics. The man never felt like he ever had enough troops to worry less.

“Simply being realistic, Ma’am.” He spoke with an unimpressed air about him.

“Well, keep being realistic. Switching channels.” She switched to the supply channel of the radio, taking in a deep breath, then breathing out. This was going… Not so horribly. Far better than

she had expected, even. She wished that she had more forces, but she'd have to make do with this. She switched to the channel of General Peters, but before she could speak to him, a radio came in, suddenly. She radioed to allow it through, before receiving it. "Field Marshal Zhuka of the 5th division."

A softer, but still gruff, voice came through to her. "This is Princess Emma of the Kingdom of Black Flag. We are coming to engage the enemy. Radio your positions now, to prevent incorrect engagements."

"Sending now -" Zhuka quickly rattled off the quadrants of exactly where the 5th's troops were stationed. "Inform your troops that any unit with a red flag or red star painted on is friendly, understand? We are still using NEA vehicles, arms, and everything else, really."

"Field Marshal, I understand completely! We would not like anything unfortunate to happen to our new comrades." Emma laughed. Zhuka couldn't tell whether she was being sarcastic or not. Was that a threat? She hoped it wasn't.

Zhuka listened as reports of sudden explosions and enemy troops cut down came in like a flood over the radio waves, combat reports flowing in by the dozens - her screen glitched, and she smirked. Good stuff, these rebels - this was their turf, and so they were playing by their rules.

Within mere minutes, the battle was over, and the 5th stood victorious, alongside their new allies. Now was the time to have something the Etherians loved; A party. The rebels from Black Flag knew well how to party, but the soldiers of the 5th were not used to having such time left to have fun, so when they did party, they partied hard.

Zhuka stood atop a table, newly set up in the main command tent where most of the troops, rebel and 5th, were gathered. "FELLOW MEMBERS OF THE FRONT," She shouted, holding high her cup of captured mead. "WE HAVE WON A GREAT VICTORY TODAY!" She

took a swig from it, grinning, her cheeks just a bit ruddy through her fur.

Everyone cheered, as they basked in the glory of this victory, of this greatness they had experienced as a new part of The Front.

Zhuka pointed to Emma, who was silently drinking wine in the corner. "Now, Coma-rades, we cannot forget that none of this would be possible without Princess Emma of Black Flag! A hurrah for Emma!" She thrust her cup up again, spilling some on her sleeve as she did.

Emma stood up and curtsied modestly, holding her skirts out slightly before sitting down again. "I thank you as well, Field Marshal Zhuka. I likewise thank all your brave soldiers."

Zhuka drained her glass completely. "AND another great call to all the people here, whoever you may be, for being the entire reason we are here right now in an alive state." She teetered on top of the table, as the 5th began a song, joining arms. She stepped off the table, and would certainly have spilled her drink more than she already had if there was any left. She licked up what was on her sleeve, before going over and pouring another two cups for herself, draining them both within several seconds. ….Then another. As her eyesight blurred, she grinned, running her fingers through her hair, trying to style the shock of unkempt brown hair into some sort of style.
She just made it stand up, but it was good enough. She listened to the singing, and took in a breath. It smelled of alcohol.

"She came ashore on the high bank of the steep, oh my love… She came out, and started a song!" Sung the 5th and rebels, joined together in this off-key chorus.

Zhuka made her way over to Emma, who was steadily drinking at a modest glass of wine. Zhuka sat down, leaning her back against the table - she could never sit straight in a chair. It was why she either stood, and sat backwards. She nudged Emma with her elbow. "It's good to see my troops and your people getting along

so well. Coma-rade" She grinned again, her cheeks blushing. Emma smirked. Was she just drunk, or nervous? Or both? Well…

Emma leaned over, chuckling. "Comrade Field Marshal, it is indeed good. But can their marshal, and their princess, get along?"

Zhuka closed her mouth for a second, thinking, before smiling in an off-kilter manner. "I sure hope so!" She reached over and fetched herself another nearby drink someone hadn't drunk yet, taking a sniff of it - ah, wodka. She downed it in record time. "Ssso, Princess Emma yourself, what's your life story?" She blinked.

"Well, my father was King Brakken himself, and my mother was Queen Em. So when I was born, they named me after my mother, but a little different. Just a bit, though." She chuckled again, and Zhuka laughed with her.

"Very creative."

"Perhaps," Emma responded. "But I hold it dear."

"I was… Named after my father, who was a marshal before me, and his father before him, and so on and so forth back to Great Leader's original coup." She reached up and rubbed at her nose. "And they named me after all of them, which makes for a long name. So I just go by Zhuka." She could really feel the alcohol getting to her now, and Emma could definitely tell. Her head was swimming, but she could take it!

She slumped backwards, laying her head on the table, giggling,

"You good, Zhuka?" Emma asked, a ghost of a smile on her face. She looked heavenly, to Zhuka, especially that cute little scruff of fur on her chin which seemed to poof out.

"Yessss, Emma." She managed out. "Jus… Just, you're so." She thought about it for a second, before deciding not to say anything.

“Uhm. Nothing. Never-the-mind.” She grinned sheepishly at her.

Emma laughed raucously as she said that, before smiling sweetly. “Don’t worry,” She looked at the curve of her neck, the way Zhuka’s lips pursed every time she thought, the way her eyes sparkled whenever she grinned. “I think you’re cute, too.” She blushed just a bit, and she couldn’t tell whether Zhuka was blushing, because her face was already red as a beet. But she probably was.

“You’re beautiful.” Zhuka mumbled out, sitting up slightly, her smile now more nervous, even embarrassed, than before. “And you wear different clothes. I… I’ve never seen someone wear a dress, except She-Ra on the posters…”

“Beautiful? Never heard anybody say that about me.” She thought of the severe lack of suitors she had had. Maybe it was the respect people had for her, maybe it was fear - she really hoped it wasn’t fear. She was a kind monarch, and one who was even more radical than her father, who had certainly managed to get hitched quite quickly. She absent-mindedly began to fidget with her hands.

“You’re doing something funny with your fingers. I do that too. When I’m feeling really nervous.” Zhuka almost whistled the words, pursing her lips again. Emma noticed that she was hiding her hands in her pockets.

“It’s nothing.” Emma quipped back as she regained her composure. “Just a tic.”

“Forests everywhere, I’ll bet you there’s a lot of ticks.” Zhuka took her right hand from her pocket and made a quick crawling motion with it, before sliding slightly down in her seat, bumping her head as she did so. “Ech.”
Emma felt a welling of worry for her, even though she was sure the professional soldier she was talking with could handle it. “You okay?”

“Yeah, fine. My head hurts.” She laughed. “Though pretty sure it was like that before I smacked myself with the edge of a table.”

“Maybe you should just lay down.”

“Yeah… I should.”

“You have a tent?” Zhuka said.

“You have a room?” Emma said.

They had said it at the same time, and at that moment, both knew this was the start of something wonderful.

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